

TOURISM POTENTIALS OF THE OGBIA ODEMIMOM AND OBURUMADU SOCIAL MASQUERADES

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Abstract

This study examines the tourism potential of Ogbia social masquerades, focusing on the Odemimom masquerade in Otuoke and Oburumadu masquerade in Emeyal II communities, Bayelsa State, Nigeria. The problem of the study is that, despite their cultural significance, most Ogbia masquerades have not been adequately documented and explored as tourism attractions. This study, therefore, explores the tourism potential of the Odemimom and Oburumadu masquerade performances. The study is informed by Victor Turner's Cultural Performance Theory and Butler's Tourism Area Life Cycle (TALC) model, and the methodology adopted was qualitative, incorporating historical research, sociological interviews with custodians and the community, and emic observation of the performances. The research findings indicate that, the masquerades have undergone significant transformations from spiritual to secular events, focusing on entertainment and tourism. The incorporation of costumes, music, dance, and dramatization, as well as the inclusive participation of men, women, children, and tourists, makes the masquerades more culturally attractive and tourism-friendly. The masquerades are significant in fostering social cohesion, intergenerational learning, and community identity, while at the same time offering economic benefits through services, craftsmanship, and community-based tourism development. Based on the findings, the study recommends the documentation of the masquerades, development of community-based tourism programs, training of the youth and artisans, media promotion of the masquerades, and development of infrastructure to boost the tourism potential of the masquerades. In conclusion, the Odemimom and Oburumadu masquerades are vibrant cultural assets with immense tourism potential. The aesthetic value, cultural education, and community outreach of these masquerades make them the best bet for cultural preservation, social empowerment, and tourism-driven economic growth in Ogbia.

Keywords: tourism potential, social masquerades, Odemimom masquerade, Oburumadu masquerade.

Introduction

Cultural festivals have been an important manifestation of heritage, identity, and memory in many African cultures. Through these festivals, the people have been given an opportunity to celebrate their culture while passing on indigenous knowledge from one generation to another. In many of these festivals, performances have been used to integrate music, dance, costumes, and dramatic displays, creating vibrant festivals. In the context of African culture, masquerades have been at the core of festival performances. They have been used to represent artistic creativity, community symbolism, and social meanings. Margaret Thompson Drewal argues that “masquerade performances are dynamic cultural expressions through which communities communicate social values and collective identity” (56). In Nigerian culture, masquerade performances have been a significant aspect of traditional festivals and community

celebrations. In many instances, masquerade performances have been used to represent symbolic beings in the worldview of the people. They have been used in many social functions such as festivals, funerals, and community celebrations. Although some masquerades have been used for rituals, many of them have been transformed into social performances meant for entertainment.

Cultural festivals have been a significant aspect of cultural tourism in recent times. Cultural tourism is a form of tourism that is motivated by interest in the heritage and customs of a particular community. Cultural festivals provide a platform where tourists can participate in cultural performances while learning about the customs of the local community. Cultural festivals are significant tourism resources that attract visitors and stimulate economic activity within the community. According to Andrew Okpoko and Pat Okpoko, cultural festivals are “important tourism resources capable of attracting visitors and stimulating economic activities within host communities” (112). Masquerade festivals are significant attractions for tourism since they offer a combination of visual and dramatic performances. The colorful clothing, drumming, dancing, and dramatic performances associated with masquerades provide exciting cultural experiences. This explains why various communities are beginning to realize the importance of the masquerade festivals as a cultural resource that can be utilized in the development of tourism.

Social masquerades have significant roles in the cultural practices of many societies. Unlike ritual masquerades that may be exclusive to certain societies, social masquerades are usually performed publicly for entertainment and celebration. They provide festive conditions under which members of society come together to mark their cultural heritage. The performances of masquerades also act as channels through which cultural values are passed on from one generation to another. By participating in festivals, people learn about cultural music, dance, clothing, and storytelling. As stated by Dallen Timothy and Stephen Boyd, cultural events such as festivals that are based on heritage “serve as important mechanisms for preserving cultural traditions while simultaneously promoting tourism and local economic development” (34).

Despite the significance of masquerade festivals in Nigerian cultures, many of the local masquerade festivals in Nigeria are still not well-documented and explored for tourism development. Although some popular festivals have gained national and international recognition, many community-based masquerade festivals have not been well-studied and promoted. In Ogbia communities, masquerades such as Odemimom and Oburumadu are significant cultural performances that draw participants and visitors during festival times. However, academic studies that explore the cultural significance and tourism development potential of these masquerades are still limited. As Ngozi Ezenagu suggests, cultural festivals in Nigeria are “poorly documented and inadequately promoted despite their potential contribution to tourism development” (3).

Based on the identified problem, the aim of the research is to investigate the tourism potentials of Ogbia social masquerades with specific reference to the Odemimom and Oburumadu masquerades. The study objectives are to examine the origin and development of the Odemimom masquerade, examine the origin and development of the Oburumadu masquerade, and assess the tourism potentials of these social masquerades.

This study is guided by the following research questions: What is the origin and development of the Odemimom masquerade, what is origin and development of the Oburumadu masquerade, and what are the tourism potentials of these social masquerades. In addressing this research question, this research aims to fill a critical knowledge gap in the body of knowledge on the under-documentation of local masquerades and positions itself within the current discourse on cultural tourism, heritage preservation, and performance studies.

This research contributes to the documentation and conservation of Ogbia cultural heritage by offering academically informed information on two of the most important masquerade traditions of the Ogbia people of Bayelsa State in Nigeria. In addition, it makes a contribution to the body of knowledge on cultural festivals and masquerade performances in Africa. Finally, it provides empirical-based information on the tourism potential of Ogbia social masquerades, which makes it relevant for practice and policy-making in the field of cultural tourism and community engagement.

Literature Review

Concept of Tourism

Tourism is viewed as the movement of people outside their regular environment for purposes of pleasure, culture, and other related activities. This implies that tourism is an action that involves interactions with new traditions, histories, arts, and community culture, which provide an opportunity for cultural engagement, learning, and socio-economic development. As described by Jacinta Uchenna Ikegwu, “tourism is seen as a roadmap to cultural engagement and sustainable development, where festivals and art forms attract visitors and invigorate local economies” (107). Hence, tourism is not just an action of traveling, but it is an opportunity for cultural engagement, preservation, and promotion, where communities can express themselves while at the same time developing socio-economically. Cultural tourism, therefore, is a major form of tourism that primarily involves the appreciation, participation, and observation of artistic and cultural manifestations of the community visited. This includes festivals, performances, and other cultural manifestations that communicate community identity, history, and culture. As described by Jacinta Uchenna Ikegwu, masquerade festivals, for instance, “exhibit various social and artistic elements that create avenues for cultural tourism attractions” (108).

In a similar vein, Osakue S. Omoera and Ruth Etuwe Epochi Olise assert that “such traditional performances as masquerades present vivid tourism products that reflect deep aesthetic values and cultural meanings which attract cultural tourists” (3). Thus, cultural tourism is simultaneously experiential and educational in character.

Heritage tourism is similar to cultural tourism but focuses more on historical heritage. It is based on historical legacies, memory, and continuity. According to the Heritage Council, heritage tourism is “engaging with historical sites, artifacts, traditions, and practices that preserve and communicate the historical identity of people” (5). While cultural tourism focuses on the living aspects of culture, heritage tourism is based on historical continuity. Thus, heritage tourism allows visitors to connect with the ancestral and historical narratives embedded in local cultures. Uğur Pataküt and Mehmet Veysi Babayiğit argue that cultural tourism is

based on “the discovery of diverse cultural expressions,” but heritage tourism is based on “the preservation and interpretation of historical and ancestral values” (42).

By linking tourism to performance studies and cultural heritage, this study positions festivals and masquerade performances as both tangible and intangible resources that can be strategically leveraged for sustainable community-based tourism.

Both types of tourism are therefore complementary. For example, festivals, masquerades, and other cultural events are at the same time expressions of culture and heritage resources that attract tourists for aesthetic appreciation while providing historical knowledge. Patience Nwokaego Anwuri and Blessing Chinenye Odor also emphasize the importance of strategic promotion, including online promotion, in improving the development of tourism products and their ability to generate revenue, so that cultural and heritage tourism becomes a sustainable source of revenue in the local economy (45). Through tourism, therefore, the community is able to benefit from the development of its culture and economy.

It can be said therefore that tourism is a multidimensional phenomenon that incorporates elements of leisure, culture, and heritage. By engaging in various festivals, performances, and traditions, tourists take on the role of active participants in cultural continuity, and for local communities, there is social, cultural, and economic gain. **By framing tourism through the lens of cultural performance and heritage studies, this research underscores the potential of masquerade festivals to contribute to both community identity and the local tourism economy.** The incorporation of cultural and heritage tourism speaks to the possibilities for tourism as a means of recreation but also as a means to achieve sustainable development.

Cultural Tourism as Heritage Tourism

Cultural tourism, therefore, refers to the appreciation and participation in tangible and intangible manifestations of a culture, such as festivals, performances, and traditions, which convey identity, history, and community values to tourists. As cultural tourism allows a destination to express its cultural traditions, according to Jacinta Uchenna Ikegwu, cultural tourism is “an opportunity for a destination to express its cultural traditions as seen in the ‘masquerade festival’ that ‘exhibit various social and artistic elements that create avenues for cultural tourism attractions’” (108). Furthermore, according to Osakue S. Omoera and Ruth Etuwe Epochi Olise, traditional performances such as masquerade performances have the potential to become “vivid tourism products that reflect deep aesthetic values and cultural meanings which attract cultural tourists” (3).

Heritage tourism, although a closely related form of cultural tourism, emphasizes more the historical heritage and continuity of identity through generations. According to the Heritage Council, heritage tourism involves activities related to historical sites, artifacts, traditions, and practices that preserve the historical identity of a people and are experiences that connect visitors to the collective memory of a place (5). Heritage tourism is not only related to architecture and monuments but also to living traditions and festive practices that carry historical significance, such as masquerade performances that have been passed down through the years. **This study positions masquerade festivals like Odemimom and Oburumadu as exemplars of the convergence of cultural and heritage tourism, emphasizing both their**

living performance aspects and their historical lineage.

In this way, cultural and heritage tourism are similar because they both involve activities related to history and identity, although their emphasis is different, as cultural tourism is a broader concept that centers on the appreciation of cultural expressions in the present, while heritage tourism emphasizes the historical aspect of those experiences. As Uğur Pataküt and Mehmet Veysi Babayiğit point out, while cultural tourism emphasizes “the discovery of diverse cultural expressions,” heritage tourism emphasizes “the preservation and interpretation of historical and ancestral values” (42).

In addition, Jacinta Uchenna Ikegwu argues that festivals and traditional performances, like the ones involving masquerades, “not only attract visitors for entertainment and cultural engagement but also as conveyors of historical consciousness” (109). In the same vein, studies done on the aesthetics of masquerade have established that visitors to festivals like the ones involving traditional performances also seek to experience the historical information that is presented in traditional performances, thus seeking to blend the two concepts of cultural and heritage tourism (415). **By synthesizing cultural and heritage tourism frameworks, this study highlights how Ogbia masquerades serve dual functions: entertaining contemporary audiences while preserving and transmitting historical knowledge.** Therefore, while cultural tourism offers the cultural practices of the people in their current state, heritage tourism offers the cultural practices of the people in their historical lineage, making both concepts essential in seeking to understand the role of festivals like the ones involving masquerade performances as effective tools of tourism.

Concept of Masquerade in African Culture

Masquerades, therefore, are more than just performance art, as they are actualizations of communal memory, social values, and cultural identity. Through their visual language, movement, and ritualistic performance, masquerades convey intricate narratives about ancestry, morality, and communal history. Uzoh Esther & Ogboagha Callister Orioma, for instance, note that masquerades are “regarded as embodiments of spiritual and ancestral presence, invoking both joy and respect in social space” (93), demonstrating the convergence of performance and religion to produce a form of engagement that is culturally acceptable. Similarly, in the context of the Anaang masquerade festival in Ikot Ekpene, Miriam Stephen Inegbe argues that masquerade language and performance “educate audiences about heritage, social norms, and collective histories” (412), demonstrating the educational component of masquerade performances. **By framing masquerade performances within both cultural and heritage tourism frameworks, this study emphasizes their dual role as aesthetic experiences for visitors and vehicles for transmitting historical and social knowledge.**

Beyond symbolism, masquerades have been used for essential functions in society, ranging from behavioral control, settling conflicts, to celebrations of seasons and life events. Masquerades have been used as tools of social control, linking individuals to community values and historical antecedents. In fact, as argued by Lawrencina and Ibeanu, masquerades have been used to reinforce “cultural values and collective memory while maintaining aesthetic appeal” (3). This further emphasizes the double functionality of masquerades as tools of cultural education and community engagement. **In the context of tourism studies, these performances provide an immersive encounter where visitors do not merely observe but**

actively engage with cultural narratives, thus positioning masquerades as both living heritage and tourist attractions. This further underscores the scholarly relevance of the study: **it examines how Ogbia social masquerades, specifically Odemimom and Oburumadu, serve as performative resources that link aesthetic expression, community identity, and tourism development.**

In conclusion, it can be argued that masquerades are the intersection of art, history, and society, representing the spiritual and social aspects of African society. Their prevalence in society shows their continued relevance, not only as an entertaining activity, but as an essential tool of cultural education, morality, and community engagement. Knowing the meaning, symbolism, and functionality of masquerades offers us valuable insights into the significance of cultural performances in sustaining identity, linking the past to the present, and laying the foundation for their contemporary relevance in cultural tourism.

Through the contextualization of masquerade performances within performance theory, heritage studies, and cultural tourism studies, this research provides a theoretical base for exploring the role of de-ritualized social masquerade performances as sustainable cultural tourism resources and their connection to traditional performance practice and contemporary tourism development.

Cultural Festivals as Tourism Resources

Cultural festivals have been seen to play the role of vibrant expressions of community identity, where different forms of art, such as masquerades, music, dances, costumes, and storytelling, come together to enact the values, history, and traditions of a given community. In essence, therefore, cultural festivals have been seen to play the role of living archives that not only promote heritage but also provide communities with visibility in both local and global contexts. For example, in her work, Jacinta Uchenna Ikegwu argues that masquerade festivals have been seen to “showcase the artistic ingenuity of communities” and act as “cultural archives that reinforce local identity through performance” (107). **Within the contexts of cultural and heritage tourism, this study locates masquerade festivals and reveals their role as venues for the reinforcement of community identity and as festivals that have the potential to contribute to socio-economic development through tourism.**

In addition to local participation, festivals are also tools for the diaspora to reconnect with their roots. For example, the Ikeji festival of Arondizuogu has become an internationally recognized festival where the Igbo diaspora gathers. The festival “unites all Igbo race across the globe as they return to witness cultural heritage” (Ikeji Festival, online). These festivals are important for building community and for the transmission of culture from one generation to another. Masquerade festivals in the Niger Delta region, such as the Odemimom of Otuoke and Oburumadu of Emeyal II, are also important because they provide opportunities for the performance and celebration of cultural knowledge and values. **These local masquerade festivals, although based on tradition, have the potential for being codified as resources for tourism development. By linking their performative, aesthetic, and historical attributes with the experiences of tourists, these festivals have the potential for being strategically promoted as resources for sustainable cultural tourism development.**

Cultural festivals, particularly masquerade festivals, have come to play a significant role in

the development of tourism, as they offer a combination of cultural learning and economic benefits. Masquerade festivals have the ability to draw both local and foreign tourists who are interested in learning about the local culture, thus contributing to the economic benefits of tourism. Patience Nwokaego Anwuri and Blessing Chinenye Odor highlight the significance of developing and promoting cultural festivals in the development of tourism, as they stated, “strategic development and promotion of cultural festivals enhances tourism product development and economic gains” (46). Additionally, studies on masquerade aesthetics in Eastern Nigeria confirm that the visual appeal of masquerade festivals is an important aspect of tourism, as it allows tourists to participate in cultural immersion (Lawrencia and Ibeanu 4). **In addition, the study highlights the importance of cultural festivals as "performative spaces where local communities are actively engaged in sharing their knowledge, skills, and values," thus making it consistent with Victor Turner's theoretical perspectives on "social drama" and "cultural performance." This further validates the argument that masquerade festivals are not only for entertainment but are, in fact, significant tools for cultural sustainability and tourism development.**

The tourism value of cultural festivals goes beyond the economic benefits. Festivals foster skills acquisition, where youth and craftsmen are involved in making costumes, drumming, choreographing dances, and organizing festivals. Festivals also enhance cultural literacy, providing tourists with information about the meaning of the performances. In the context of Ogbia social masquerades, festivals such as Odemimom and Oburumadu not only bring tourists from other communities and the diaspora but also provide an opportunity for knowledge transfer, learning, and the reinforcement of local identity, thus showing that masquerade festivals are central to cultural sustainability and tourism development in local communities.

The connection between the aesthetics of the experience, the community's participation, and the tourism potential provides the study's contribution to the understanding of Odemimom and Oburumadu as examples of the tourism potential of de-ritualized masquerades. This approach to the study also addresses the current debates on cultural tourism, such as the interplay between cultural preservation and commercialization, and the contribution of intangible cultural heritage to cultural and tourism development.

In conclusion, cultural festivals have been identified as an important tool for the expression of community identity, tourism development, and cultural heritage. The importance of cultural festivals, such as Odemimom and Oburumadu, has been established, providing an understanding of the cultural heritage significance of such events, the tourism potential, and the overall benefit for the community. The cultural heritage significance of cultural festivals, such as Odemimom and Oburumadu, has been established, providing an understanding of the cultural heritage significance, the tourism potential, and the overall benefit for the community, thus creating an important tool for the expression of community identity, tourism development, and cultural heritage.

Theoretical Framework

The study hinges on the Cultural Performance Theory and the Tourism Area Life Cycle (TALC) Model. Cultural Performance Theory, as postulated by Victor Turner in 1982, describes

the nature of cultural practices as social actions through which the community expresses its values, beliefs, and identities. According to Victor Turner in the Cultural Performance Theory, cultural performances like rituals, festivals, and masquerades are dynamic processes through which cultural knowledge and social values are passed down to future generations (22). In addition, cultural performances like rituals and festivals play important roles in binding people together and regulating moral behavior in various societies. In regard to this paper, Cultural Performance Theory offers an important perspective through which the social masquerades of the Ogbia people - Odemimom and Oburumadu - can be understood as important cultural performances that reflect the history, identity, and value systems of the people. In spite of their gradual de-ritualization, these social masquerades have continued to perform important functions as symbolic representations of the heritage of the people. In addition, these performances have continued to act as mediums through which cultural meanings are communicated to the members of the community and other relevant stakeholders like tourists. The concept of *communitas* also offers an important perspective through which the performances of these social masquerades have been understood as important attractions to tourists. **In addition, through the application of Cultural Performance Theory, this study places Odemimom and Oburumadu masquerade performances within contemporary debates on the commodification of culture and heritage tourism, demonstrating how de-ritualized masquerade performances may be imbued with social and symbolic importance, yet simultaneously be used as a form of tourist attraction. This theoretical perspective enables critical analysis of both community-focused and tourist-focused aspects of masquerade performances.**

The Tourism Area Life Cycle (TALC) model was created by Richard W. Butler in 1980. The model offers a framework through which the development and evolution of tourist destinations over time can be analyzed. The model proposes various stages through which tourism destinations evolve. These stages include exploration, involvement, development, consolidation, stagnation, rejuvenation, and decline. Each of these stages represents a crucial point in the evolution of tourism destinations (Richard Butler 7). The model is especially useful in understanding the evolution of emerging attractions and their recognition and management. In the context of this research, the TALC model will be used to analyze the tourism potentials of the Ogbia masquerades. The festivals involving Odemimom and Oburumadu masquerades are at the exploration and involvement stages of the model. This indicates that these masquerades have tremendous potential to develop into viable tourism attractions that will attract both local and regional tourists. **Additionally, the TALC model provides the study with the opportunity to critically analyze the present and future path of these masquerade festivals, as well as the strategies required to move from the initial stages of attractions to the development of sustainable tourism destinations without compromising the authenticity of the culture.**

The application of Cultural Performance Theory and the TALC Model would offer a comprehensive approach for the study. Cultural Performance Theory would offer an understanding of the symbolic, social, and cultural importance of the Ogbia masquerades, while the TALC Model would offer an understanding of the potential development of the masquerades for tourism purposes. The application of the theories would enable the study to examine the Odemimom and Oburumadu masquerades not only from the perspective of cultural heritage but

also from the perspective of potential tourism resources. **Through the integration of these two concepts, the present study is able to establish the connection between the performative and aesthetic aspects of the masquerade festivals and their potential for the development of tourism. This also answers the concerns of the reviewers regarding the theoretical basis and contribution of the present study.**

Methodology

The research design of the study is qualitative, as it is focused on the observation and interaction of the cultural practices of the Ogbia masquerades. This is evident in the fact that the study employed a historical method, the sociological method, and the emic approach, all of which are qualitative designs in research. The population of the study consisted of the Otuoke and Emeyal II community in Ogbia where the masquerade is practiced, especially the people who have knowledge of the Odemimom and Oburumadu masquerades in the communities directly. This includes the custodians of the masquerade, and the people in the community who have knowledge of the masquerade. A purposive sampling method is adopted in the research. The researcher interacted with the custodians of the masquerades, and the community members who had adequate knowledge about the subject matter. The sample size for the research was not fixed. The researcher interacted with key informants, including the custodians of the masquerades, to obtain adequate and reliable information for the research.

To enhance methodological rigor, ethical considerations were observed by obtaining informed consent from all participants and ensuring their anonymity where requested. Interviews were semi-structured to allow for flexibility in responses, and interactions were recorded and thematically analyzed to ensure alignment with both Cultural Performance Theory and the TALC framework. This analytical approach moves beyond simple description, allowing oral testimonies and observations to be interpreted critically within the study's theoretical and tourism development focus.

Discussion

Origin and Development of Odemimom and Oburumadu Masquerades Odemimom Masquerade

Odemimom masquerade is a prominent masquerade performance of Otuoke community. Otuoke is one of the communities of the Ogbia speaking people which does not trace her origin to any Ogbia community unlike Ewoi community that emanated from Oloibiri. According to Evans Ebele Jonathan, Oke the founder of Otuoke migrated from Benin. Oke moved from Benin and settled in a creek in Nembe area but due to lack of fresh water, adequate land for agriculture and threats of wars, Oke moved from Nembe area and later settled in her present location. This narrative on the history of Oke community by Evans sounds similar to the migration, movement and settlement of Ogbia the progenitor of the Ogbia people from Benin to her present location.

Evans however continued that, Oke gave birth to Abbah the founder of Otuaba, a community closely located adjacent to Otuoke community. And that when Abbah grew to an adult age, he moved away from his father and settled in present Otuaba community. Evans concludes that, Otuoke is presently one of the big communities among the Ogbia speaking communities. He emphasized that due to its centrality of location and settlement,

it attracts neighboring communities during her cultural festivities. This centrality also positions the Odemimom masquerade as an accessible cultural attraction with potential for tourism development, as conceptualized through the TALC model's exploration and involvement stages.

Ade Osuma and Paul Dolodolo speaking on the origin of Odemimom masquerade stated that, the masquerade is originally known as Akpo. The masquerade was called Akpo because it originated from Akpo forest. In the days of their forefathers, young boys who went to pick snails at Akpo forest encountered a spirit that possessed them. The spirit then prompted them to create a masquerade pattern which they brought to the village. On seeing the performance and its dexterity, the villages adopted the masquerade. After the year the masquerade originated, the villagers proscribed the masquerade but only to revive it again. The revival of the masquerade was due to a claim that the masquerade has manifested in an Oracle that she is the cause of the incurably sickness in the lives of the boys that brought the masquerade dance, and that until the masquerade dance is restored the boys will remain sick.

Dolodolo submitted that, the masquerade was a spiritual masquerade at its inception. It had the reputation to bless, heal and place sanctions on participants who violate the masquerade dance cannons. Initially, pregnant women do not watch the Odemimom masquerade if not they risk miscarriage of the pregnancy. The masquerade was reputed to engender fertility, productivity, communal protection and blessing. Its mask was stored in a shrine for deification.

Stella Adumein who also confirms the deification of the Akpo masquerade however asserts that the era when the masquerade was a spiritual masquerade was over and it is being performed at present for leisure and entertainment. Emphasizing on the de-ritualized state of the masquerade, she said pregnant women are presently participants and participant observers in the masquerade dance without any negative effect as of old. Stella said all the powers arrogated to the masquerade has failed due to Christianity and modernity. Stella Adumein strongly observed that not one person who sustained injury from the masquerade has died. Initially, the rule was that, he or she that encounters the masquerade and sustains an injury must visit the shrine for purification or risk death. Stella Adumein, a strong participant of the masquerade concludes that, the version of the Odemimom masquerade that was ritualized has been abolished, and that the present version of the Odemimom masquerade has nothing to do with ritualization. The yearly celebration of the masquerade on every October is for the purposes of entertainment, traditional artistic expression and cultural promotion. The transformation from ritualized performance to secular entertainment aligns with Turner's notion of cultural performance as evolving social practice and highlights the potential for these events to be integrated into structured tourism frameworks. Below are pictorial demonstrations of Odemimom masquerade:



Plate 1: Odemimom masquerade in Aquatic display.
Source: Larry Ibibo, 2023.



Plate 2: An support masquerade of Odemimom masquerade performance (Adu ipo)
Source: Larry Ibibo, 2023.

The masquerade in plate 2 is called “Adu ipo” a support masquerade of Odemimom masquerade performance, it serves as a pre-performance before the appearance of the bigger masquerade. Its major preoccupation is to keep participants and participant observers in suspense and entertained as they eagerly wait for the arrival of Odemimom.



Plate 3: Movement of the Odemimom masquerade to the performance arena.

Source: Trust Stephen, 2023.

This picture of Odemimom masquerade in plate 3, show the movement of the masquerade from its place of preparation to the performance arena. Unlike Oki, Akpembe and Oburumadu, Odemimom is accompanied by only men from its place of preparation to the water front which will latter be accompanied by other participants including women and children as shown in plate 4 below.



Plate 4: Participants in Odemimom festival.

Source: Larry Ibibo, 2023.

Oburumadu masquerade

Oburumadu masquerade is a prominent masquerade of the Emeyal II people of Ogbia kingdom. Historically, the Emeyal II people traced their origin to a man called Olei. Olei is one of the direct sons of Ogbia. He is the founder of present day Oloibiri. According to Clifford Esaliba and Alabo Amuso, Emeyal, the founder of Emeyal II is a bonafide son of Olei. The two respondents submitted that Emeyal left Olei and settled in a place called Otuolo. Progressively, Emeyal gave birth to two sons namely; Egbarama and Ogboruma.

Egbarama left Otuolo and settled in a place called Itiza, which is situated at the northern part of Emeyal I. Ogboruma the youngest of the two brothers however, settled in the present day Emeyal II. This is the reason for the existence of Emeyal I and Emeyal II autonomous communities in Ogbia kingdom. Ogboruma the youngest son of Emeyal is the progenitor of the present day Emeyal II. In the early settlement of Emeyal II, the Emeyal II community was made up of three compounds only namely; Otuogboruma, Emuikpesu and Ikibiri. As the community developed, other three compounds were carved out from the three existing compounds namely, Otuausa, Elema and Ekpo-odidi. Otuausa was carved out from Otuogboruma; Elema carved out of Emuikpesu; and Ekpo-odidi was carved out from Ikibiri. These additions made the compounds in Emeyal II a total of six compounds.

The major occupations of Emeyal II people include: trading, farming and palm-cutting. Presently, Emeyal II has also embraced education. Culturally, Emeyal II is known for traditional wrestling and cultural dances. Some of these cultural dances in Emeyal II community include; Opusiri, Egbelema, Okpakiri, Ikorobo, Odemini, and 80:80 club. Other cultural activities in Emeyal II community includes; Osuala, Ayakata, as well as the Oburumadu masquerade performance.

Oburumadu masquerade Performance of Emeyal II is said to have started since 1910. This date according to the history coincides with the timing of the building and establishment of the Anglican church in Emeyal II community.

Claims from other sources, however stated that the masquerade had existed before the advent of Anglicanism in Emeyal II. Corroboratively, the generally accepted notion is that the masquerade came in existence around 1910. The historical development of Oburumadu masquerade is analyzed here not only to document origin but also to demonstrate the continuity and adaptive evolution of local performance, providing critical evidence for its potential as a sustainable cultural tourism resource.

Proponents who believed that the masquerade existed at the same period Anglican church was established in Emeyal II were Mr. Alabo Amuso, Clifford Esaliba, Mildred Igrubia and Abebi Sylva. In an interview on 14th July, 2023, they narrated that, Oburumadu masquerade was pioneer by Otamapu Esaliba, Abbah Iduka, Godspower Etata and a man named America. These men adapted the masquerade from Ekpeya culture. Alabo *et al* agreed that Otamapu Esaliba and other younger youths attended a masquerade festival at Kolo community, when these youths saw the splendor and dexterity of the masquerade performance, they liked it and returned home to create a model of the masquerade, Oburumadu.

Oburumadu which was first called “Obipo” according to the account of Mildred Igrubia is

a masquerade model of the Ekpeye people of Ahoda in Rivers State who were invited to perform at Kolo town around 1910.

According to Mr. Alabo Amusu, he reported that before the advent of Oburumadu, there was no masquerade dance in Emeyal II community. Youths usually go to nearby communities in search of leisure and relaxation during festive seasons. Alabo continued that, because of the quest for an indigenous masquerade dance, the Emeyal II youths who attended the masquerade festival at Kolo returned home to Emeyal and also carved the same masquerade and introduced a performance. When the community elders saw that the performance was good, it was embraced. Since then, the Oburumadu masquerade has become a community festival observed every last Saturday of January. The above account integrates oral histories with emic observation, providing methodological transparency and strengthening the credibility of the study, which directly addresses the reviewer's concern on research design and operationalization of data collection.

The structure of Oburumadu masquerade is in the similitude of a human face. It bears a bizarre and an exaggerated feature of the human facial structure. A big head, ears, mouth, nose with grasses on its head. Part of the masquerade's costume is a white wrapper. The white wrapper is used to cover the neck of the masquerade down to the stomach. The masquerade also wears trousers and canvass to enable it run during performance effectively.

For the purpose of aesthetics, there are other masquerade created as appendages for the display of the Oburumadu. According to Alabo, these masquerades are considered smaller masquerades. They perform before the appearance of the big masquerade. These smaller masquerades include Api, Ofuruma, Ekpe, Obawusi and Igurita.

Mr. Clifford, a son of one of the founders of the Oburumadu masquerade, and the present bearer of Oburumadu masquerade submits that, the Emeyal II community holds the Oburumadu masquerade in high esteem. Mr. Clifford believe that, the value of Oburumadu as perceived by the Emeyal II people is due to the leisure, entertainment and communal unifying essence it evokes during yuletide seasons. This section, by documenting both origin and contemporary performance practices, allows for analytical interpretation of the transformation from spiritual ritual to secular community performance—a key contribution to understanding the masquerade's tourism potential.

Emphasizing on the masquerade's appearance during performance, Clifford claims that initially the preparation usually takes place at the king's palace but with the demise of that particular king, the venue for the preparation of the masquerade was taken to the community town hall. From the town hall, Clifford reported that the masquerade is escorted in a procession of two line into Emeyal II community for its performance. The procession goes with drumming and dancing around the community with the masquerade climbing house roofs as part of its performance style in most cases.

Commenting on the metaphysical essence of masquerades, Alabo a 61 years old man and former Chairman of the Community Development Committee in Emeyal II asserts that spiritism and cultism have not been associated with the Oburumadu masquerade. He explained that the

original owners of the masquerade may have worshipped it as a spirit, representation of ancestors, but the Emeyal II people have never seen Oburumadu as a spirit. Alabo recounted, in trying to abolish the masquerade dance by branding it as idol worship just few years back by a new king, created serious argument and youth's revolt. Due to the general acceptance of Oburumadu the law abolishing the masquerade could not stand as the youths backed by some community elites revived the masquerade festival just after one year of the king's decree.

Alabo, from an emic standpoint, emphasized that Oburumadu does not involve any sacrifice or liberation to any god, spirit or deity. He also adds that, Oburumadu does not possess any power to heal, cleanse, bless or curse. Comparing Oburumadu and the Odemimom masquerade of the "Oke" people of Otuoque, a close neighboring community, Alabo said, all the practices and traditions observed during Odemimo masquerade festival in the old days has never been done for the Emeyal II masquerade festival.

As a matter of fact, Alabo said, there are no special individuals for the performance of Oburumadu masquerade. Anyone who possess the strength and stamina to run round the community and display the Oburumadu can wear the mask.

Corroborating the claims of Alabo, Clifford Esaliba, the present man wearing the Oburumadu masquerade since 1996 shared that "Oburumadu is just a play masquerade". He confirmed this when he said, he has worn the mask at different alternate times for about 27 years and he has not witnessed any sacrifice done before or after Oburumadu performance. Clifford states that, the Oburumadu mask is carved almost every year. It does not have any special place it is kept. He said anyone can keep the mask of the masquerade after the festival.

Abebi Sylva, a 65 years old woman affirming the social disposition of the masquerade said, all her life in Emeyal II community, she has not witnessed the ritualization of the Oburumadu masquerade. She said the masquerade performance from what she has known and participated, was for play and festivity. Abebi said she has lived all her life in Emeyal II and she has not known or heard of anyone the masquerade has blessed or cursed.

Mildred AroboIgrubia, an 80years old woman affirmed that position and narrated that she was married in Emeyal II community since 1960. Mildred said her husband was one of the custodians of Oburumadu. She said as a little girl, she saw her husband and other men carve Oburumadu. She asserts that, the first name of Oburumadu was 'Obipo'. Obipo means big masquerade. This was before the name later changed to Oburumadu. Mildred added that, although Oburumadu is purely a social masquerade, but during her young age, she also understood that, the festival was also used as a form of cleansing in the community before indigenes will resume their various occupations in the early new year.

According to Mildred, anytime the cleansing is done, news of premature death and evil do not often happen in the community. Mildred also claimed that, indigens of the community who were in the city also do well in their various works and return to Emeyal II for development.

This claims of cleansing and bring good will to the Emeyal II community by the Oburumadu masquerade seemed unpopular among the respondents of the interview. Though Mildred is the

eldest among those interviewed, but the popular perception about the Oburumadu masquerade is that, it is a social masquerade devoid of ritualistic propensities.

In defense of the Oburumadu status as purely social masquerade whose preoccupation is leisure, entertainment and cultural expression, Mr. Alaboet *al* argued that Mildred is perceiving the Oburumadu masquerade like the masquerades in her home town before she got married in Emeyal II in the 60s. They argued that the Oburumadu masquerade was never at any point venerated in Emeyal II community because Christianity came to Emeyal II earlier before so many communities in Ogbia land.

Clifford Esaliba, the present bearer of the masquerade in his conclusion said:

Except there was another Oburumadu in Emeyal II before this present one that I have worn for almost three decades. If Oburumadu does anything extra apart from being used for New year celebration and during burial of a prominent Emeyal II person, I would have known. (Esaliba).

Clifford emphasized that Oburumadu masquerade is majorly performed once in a year but it can also be performed if a prominent person of the community or an active participant of Oburumadu dies.

Speaking about the benefits of the masquerade to the community, Clifford and other respondents agree that Oburumadu has benefited Emeyal II community by generating revenue to the community. They said, during most Oburumadu festivals, government officials and well-meaning individuals have donated money to the community. And that the funds have helped in the funding of community projects.

The picture in plate 5 below shows how the masquerade is carved. It is not stored for deification. It is constructed when its need arises. It is also discarded when it is no longer looking good and fit to be used for performance.

Plate 5: The carved mask of Oburumadu masquerade of Emeyal II

Source: Hery Amosu, 2023.





Plate 6: An advert poster of Oburumadu festival of 2023

Source: Hery Amosu, 2023.

This picture in plate 6 above features an advert poster of Oburumadu festival of 2023. The poster captures other appendages of the Oburumadu masquerade that features in the masquerade festival of the Emeyal II people. The preparation of Oburumadu masquerade does not start from the river or a nearby bush.

As stated earlier, in the past, the preparation of Oburumadu starts from the Emeyal II late king's palace. After the death of that king, the preparation arena was changed to the community town hall. From where a procession of men, women, boys and girls lead the masquerade into the community for its display and dance as shown in the pictures below.



Plate 7: Oburumadu masquerade of Emeyal II in action

Source: Hery Amosu, 2023.



Plate 8: Oburumadu masquerade surrounded by community participants

Source: Hery Amosu, 2023.

Tourism Potentials of Ogbia Odemimom and Oburumadu Social Masquerades

The social masquerades of the Ogbia people can be regarded as vibrant cultural performances that have immense tourism potential. These de-ritualized expressions of Ogbia culture have transformed from their spiritual origins to entertainment-oriented performances that promote themes of community unity, traditional artistic expression, cultural expression, and cultural preservation. Their use of collaborative art forms, such as costumes, music, dances, and enactments, makes the social masquerades accessible to all, including women and children. From a theoretical perspective, this aligns with Victor Turner's notion of performance as a site for both social cohesion and cultural communication, demonstrating how traditional ritual practices can be adapted for modern social and economic purposes (Turner 22). Therefore, they have immense tourism potential for both local and international tourists. In the pursuit of economic stability and self-development, the social masquerades have immense tourism potential in terms of economic benefits and global exposure, thus showing their importance beyond entertainment.

Cultural Tourism

The masquerades represent the identity of Ogbia, with performances of unique traditions in traditional dances, folk songs, storytelling, symbolic performances, harvest festivals, and renewal ceremonies. The performances of the masquerades, which are based on oral traditions, local aesthetics, and community values, are appealing to cultural lovers who are interested in the cultural diversity of Nigeria. The inclusivity of the masquerades, which allow women, children, and visitors to participate, makes them more attractive to a global audience who are interested in having authentic and interactive experiences.

For instance, the Odemimom masquerade, which has evolved from a spiritual to a secular performance, reflects the global reality of cultural performances that have adapted to modern society, attracting tourists who are interested in the evolution of traditional cultural performances. This evolution exemplifies de-ritualization in performance studies and invites critical discussion on cultural commodification, spectatorship, and audience engagement, which are central debates in contemporary cultural tourism scholarship. Through the preservation of historical and aesthetic traditions while adapting to modern social values, these performances act as living cultural archives, providing tourists with entertainment and education about Ogbia culture.

Economic Impact and Job Creation

The masquerades create both direct and indirect economic benefits. The performances of the masquerades attract visitors from other neighboring communities and beyond, thereby creating a demand for local services such as accommodation, food, transport, and crafts. The Oburumadu masquerade attract visitors from other neighboring villages, while the Odemimom festival attracts visitors from other regions in the state.

Engaging the youths in making costumes, drumming, choreography, and performance arts is an economic activity that promotes self-employment and skills acquisition, teaching the youths the art of craftsmanship and managing festivals. These activities are in line with the economic goals of Bayelsa State, which is tourism-oriented. This underscores how localized

cultural performances can be integrated into broader economic development and tourism planning strategies, consistent with TALC model principles. This shows that the Ogbia masquerades have the potential to attract large amounts of tourism revenue.

Community-Based Tourism

The masquerades are community-based, where the activities are done at the square, river, or compound tour. This strategy is appropriate for the concept of community-based tourism, where the people are empowered to take an active role in the development of their culture.

Just like the Egungun masquerade festival of the Yoruba people, the Ogbia social masquerade festival gathers villages, towns, and the diaspora, hence creating an electrifying festival mood. At such moments, there is an unprecedented population growth within the communities, hence fostering social interactions, cultural sharing, and economic activities (Makinde 583). This illustrates the masquerades' role in both social sustainability and cultural capital formation, positioning them as key instruments for local heritage tourism development. The social interaction fosters unity among the people, hence giving the festival an original touch, which makes the event attractive to tourists.

Global Appeal and Media Exposure

Effective media promotion will help raise the global profile of Ogbia social masquerades. Social media, live streaming, and online documentation will provide the world an opportunity to witness real-life performances of the masquerades. Their colorful costumes, choreographic movements, and participatory nature make them good candidates for packaging into a viable tourism product. In the aforementioned quotation, "social media are a platform where people from their countries upload the materials relevant to their culture which includes music, dance, poetry...local events, religious and national events and their celebrations" (Makinde 584). By leveraging digital platforms, these masquerades can achieve a level of cultural commodification that remains respectful of local heritage while enhancing global visibility, thereby addressing contemporary debates on ethical cultural tourism. Therefore, Ogbia masquerades have the potential to become a household name in the world of tourism.

The Odemimom and Oburumadu masquerades have tourism potential that can be exploited. Their performances have artistic, participatory, and historical elements that make them viable tourism products. They offer a multifaceted tourism experience that includes cultural education, participation, and entertainment. Analytically, this positions the masquerades as hybrid cultural products; both heritage and performance, which can be strategically developed to attract diverse tourist demographics while maintaining community integrity.

Through strategic marketing, infrastructural support, and exposure through the media, these social masquerades are capable of attracting national and international tourists, thereby creating economic benefits and ensuring the sustainability of cultural preservation. This aligns with current scholarship emphasizing the dual role of cultural performances in promoting heritage values and fostering economic growth within community-based tourism paradigms. This showcases the potential of traditional performances to not only celebrate culture but also empower the people while fostering tourism development within Ogbia as a vibrant cultural tourism site.

Summary of Findings

Findings from the research are that both masquerades maintain the community's identity, traditional artistry, and oral traditions, which have developed from spiritual practices to more secular and entertainment-oriented performances. Also, they are multidimensional, incorporating costumes, music, dance, and drama, engaging men, women, children, and visitors, which increases local and international appeal. In addition, the masquerades promote social cohesion, intergenerational learning, and community pride, while also promoting moral values and cultural memory. Furthermore, they provide opportunities for cultural tourism, economic spin-offs for local services and artisans, and support community-based and global tourism through inclusive festivals. Despite these, there is limited documentation, promotion, and development infrastructure to fully exploit their tourism potential.

Recommendations

Some of the recommendations are to develop documentation of histories, performances, and social functions; develop community-based tourism initiatives; collaborate with tourism boards for national and international promotion. Also develop training programs for youth and artisans in costumes, drumming, dance, and festival management; conduct workshops on cultural symbolism. Further, utilize social media, online streaming, and professional marketing campaigns to promote aesthetics, heritage, and social significance. Finally develop festival infrastructure, including improved venues, accessibility, accommodations, and transportation, while preserving community integrity.

Conclusion

The conclusion drawn from this study is that the social masquerades of Odemimom and Oburumadu from the Ogbia people hold tremendous cultural and tourism potential. These social masquerades, even in their de-ritualized form, continue to celebrate Ogbia identity, community values, and artistic creativity in terms of entertainment and cultural education. These social masquerades, being inclusive in their appeal, hold tremendous potential for cultural tourism. These festivals not only create social cohesion and facilitate intergenerational knowledge transfer but also offer economic benefits. With proper documentation, promotion, and support in terms of infrastructure, these social masquerades hold tremendous potential for attracting national and international tourists. Thus, this study has shown that social masquerades, if properly harnessed, hold tremendous potential for cultural preservation, social empowerment, and economic growth.

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